

our high promise of service to investors. Someone's got to do it. By the process of elimination, I got the job.

5. Because when the battler stands pretty much alone, he draws a lot more attention to the mission. If you have a large ego (I do), that's a nice extra dividend, especially because those who are *outside* the system—our “man in the street” investors, exemplified by the Bogleheads of the Internet—give me the strength to carry on.
4. Because, sad to say, I no longer play squash, and playing golf on grown-up courses is now something of a stretch. So what else can I do but transfer the spirit of those old battles on the fields of athletic combat onto the fields of combat to improve our society at large?
3. Because what I'm battling for—building our nation's financial system anew, in order to give our citizen/ investors a fair shake—is *right*. Mathematically right. Philosophically right. Ethically right. Call it idealism, and it's as strong today as—maybe even stronger than—it was when I wrote that idealistic Princeton thesis 57 years ago. How could an idealist fail to fight such a battle?
2. Because, even as I battle, I love the give-and-take, the competition, the intellectual challenge of my field, the burning desire to leave everything that I touch better than I found it. Using Robert Frost's formulation, my battle is “a lover's quarrel” with our financial world.
1. Simply because I'm a battler by nature—born, bred, and raised to make my own way in life. Such a life demands the kind of passion evoked by the words of the great sculptor of Mount Rushmore, Gutzon Borglum: “Life is a kind of campaign. People have no idea what strength comes to one's soul and spirit through a good fight.”

While I simply can't imagine that my own soul and spirit will ever fade, I know deep down that time is not on my side. So I'll continue to fight the battle until my mind and strength at last begin to dull. Only then, I hope many moons from now, will I take time to revel in